Punchayet in 1954, just after the avid collector Alpaiwalla passed away leaving behind his considerable collection that reportedly didn't even fit into his 11-room mansion! According to the Punchayet, the archaeological and ethnographic museum has two overall goals: 'To preserve the identity, culture and religious history of the Parsi Iranian Zoroastrian community and to reach out to the larger world and present the diversity of India within which the Zoroastrians have lived and flourished.'

Curator Kerman Fatakia shows us around the well-displayed collections divided across seven 'stories' that connect the origins of the Zoroastrians to their material and spiritual progression and their subsequent life on the subcontinent. Right from the community's early migrations to their evolving attire, and even their success in the opium trade resulting in Chinese influence on their daily lives (think silk *gara* sarees elaborately embroidered with oriental motifs or exquisite porcelain objets d'art). There's a beautiful recreation of a fire temple with all the symbols and accessories that non-Zoroastrians aren't allowed access to in the real ones in India.

While the celebration of culture is wonderful, Karkaria issues a timely warning: "Like many threatened minorities, we are trapped between pride and paranoia over the bequests of past glory being grabbed by 'outsiders'. The young especially need to get off their butts and their bikes and reclaim our old place in the larger professional and social landscape, not wallow in deadening comfort zones." ■

–Priya Pathiyan

ARCHITECTURE

WALK IN THE CLOUDS

Mumbai's elated with its **elevated walkway** at Malabar Hill

You book a slot online, arrive on time, scan the QR code at the turnstile, and unlock a whole new level of Mumbai magic at the newly opened Malabar Hill Walkway. Every day, from 5 am to 8 pm, 200 enthusiastic visitors fill each hourly slot, taking their time to explore the walkway, reading the plaques introducing them to the large variety of trees, birds and other creatures that live in the lush forest, breathing in the fresh air, feasting their eyes on the vibrant colours of nature, and (of course) taking plenty of photographs to document their experience on the elevated forest trail.

Funded by the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC), the 482-metre walkway follows the path of two older ground-level trails that were carved through the forest in pre-Independence times, but at a height that ranges from 2-10 metres, adapting to the natural terrain. Rahul Kadri, partner & principal architect at IMK Architects, who conceptualised the walkway, is especially proud that the trail was built without harming a single tree.

Having spent many decades strolling through the same forest as a child and later with his dog, Kadri had an 'aha!' moment when he visited it with his wife Shimul (a fellow architect), coming up with the idea of an elevated walkway that would help preserve the natural water flow and wildlife movement by regulating visitor access and minimising concrete use on the forest floor. Deciding to take it up as a CSR (corporate social responsibility) project through his firm, he created three designs and then got the support of the Nepean Sea Road Citizens' Forum; Sangita Jindal, chairperson of the JSW Foundation; and Aditya Thackeray, former cabinet minister, Government of Maharashtra. After that, the project was greenlighted, and things progressed very smoothly.

While the planning took just 3-4 months, they wanted it to be executed slowly, without using any heavy machinery in the forest. It took them about three years to build the walkway onsite. The cost of Rs 26 crore was borne entirely by the BMC. The foundations are concrete, while the main structural system is made of steel columns with struts for support. The walkway itself is made of Merbau wood, an Indonesian variant that is now grown in Kerala. "It only needs to be oiled once a year, and the epoxy-coated steel structure needs a repaint every five years or so. And that can be done from below the walkway, so it won't disturb the forest walk at all," says Kadri. ■

–Priya Pathiyan





Photographs by **MANDAR DEODHAR**

PERCHED ON TOP Architect Rahul Kadri on the Malabar Hill Walkway in Mumbai; (below) a bird's eye view

Every day, from 5 am to 8 pm, 200 visitors fill hourly slots, taking their time to explore the walkway